

Respectful Competitor-in-Place Opener

SCRIPT | SKILL: OBJECTIONS | DIFFICULTY: ADVANCED | EST. 8 MIN

Reviewed professional resource - AmplifyHub Practical Resource Library

Overview

An approach for prospects who already use a competitor - it respects their current choice, asks what is and is not working, and offers a specific difference instead of trash-talking the incumbent.

Learning objectives

- Respect the prospect's existing decision
- Learn what works and what they would change
- Offer one concrete, honest point of difference
- Never disparage the competitor

Approach in four beats

1. Acknowledge they already have a solution - no surprise, no judgment.
2. Ask what is working well before anything else.
3. Ask the one thing they would change if they could.
4. Only if there is a real gap, offer one specific difference you can stand behind.

Talk about them, not the competitor

- Never call the incumbent bad - it insults their choice and your credibility.
- Anchor on the change they named, not on a feature war.
- If they are genuinely happy, thank them and leave the door open.

Professional standard

Professional objection handling is diagnosis, not debate. Acknowledge the concern, clarify it once, and respond only when there is useful information to add. Repeated or firm rejection ends the conversation.

Professional workflow

1. Research the account and role before editing the script. Record one observable business signal, one plausible problem to test, and the source that supports the signal.
2. Replace every bracketed placeholder with plain language you would genuinely use. Remove claims, customer names, statistics, and urgency that you cannot verify.
3. Read the script aloud at normal speed. Shorten any sentence that forces you to rush, breathe in the middle, or sound as if you are reading.
4. Practise three variations: the intended flow, an early interruption, and a clear no. The goal is calm adaptation, not perfect memorisation.
5. After use, record only the outcome category and one learning point. Adjust one line at a time so you know which change improved clarity or relevance.

Quality-control review

Review point

Acknowledgement

Professional standard

The response recognises the concern before asking another

Warning sign

The answer begins with a rebuttal or correction.

	question.	
Diagnosis	One neutral question identifies timing, fit, value, authority, or information needs.	Several questions are stacked to wear down resistance.
Response	The reply addresses the stated concern with verifiable information.	The reply changes the subject or uses an unsupported claim.
Exit discipline	A clear no is thanked and respected immediately.	The same objection is challenged more than once.

Evidence and improvement signals

- Classify objections by underlying reason instead of memorising a separate comeback for every phrase.
- Review whether your clarifying question produced new information or simply prolonged the call.
- Track calmness and listening quality, not only meetings booked after an objection.
- Add a response to your playbook only after you can support it with accurate product or process information.

Worked example

"You are already using Meridian - good tool, I am not here to knock it. Out of curiosity, what is working well with it for you? ... And if you could change one thing about it, what would it be? ... The reporting delay you mentioned is actually the one area we are built differently, so that might be worth a look. If everything is fine as-is, though, I will not try to talk you out of a setup that works."

Safe-practice note

Never disparage a competitor or imply the prospect made a poor choice - it damages trust and often backfires. Only claim a difference you can genuinely deliver and demonstrate. If the prospect is satisfied with what they have, respect that and leave without pressure.

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